The Clock, Not the Culture — the two-page brief

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Working paper, version 1.6, September 2026

This brief summarises a 67-page working paper. Each section is one stage of the argument; every claim below is developed, sourced and bounded in the full text.

The idea

If one person's behavior at work can be predicted — weakly, conditionally, but measurably — can a team's? A team that includes an AI colleague? A company's? A multinational's? Five literatures each hold a piece of the answer and none holds the whole. The paper asks the question once, across all five levels, and finds that prediction does not fail as you climb; it changes its translation rule at every boundary.

The concept

The discipline comes from an unlikely place: forty years of measurement on Darwin's finches. The same beak that saved the population in the 1977 drought was a liability by 1985 — the same trait is an asset or a liability depending on the regime, and a prediction that ignores the regime is a prediction about the wrong thing. The arrival of AI in the workplace is read as exactly such a regime change: a drought in which the seed supply changed rather than shrank. One equation carries across — $R = h^2S$: an organisation's response to any shock is bounded by how hard the environment pushes, times how much the organisation retains from one cycle to the next. An organisation that reorganises every five months cannot respond to anything, however hard it is pushed.

The trial

The paper contributes original data at the level where the literature is thinnest: 9,772 measurements administering the instruments organisations use on people — a DISC-format inventory, a Big Five questionnaire, and a battery of repeated-play games — to AI colleagues configured the way real functions configure them: six corporate roles, working documents included, across four model versions from two providers. A nine-country field lens, drawn from twenty years of senior management roles in energy infrastructure, tests the framework's upper levels.

The findings

The function writes the AI colleague's personality: the role explains 65 to 92 per cent of its measured style, the model behind it under 10. Under the same role, rival vendors' models are nearly interchangeable — on paper. But the questionnaire measures the wet year; the games measure the drought, and in the drought the model shows through: behavior under provocation belongs to the model family, and it moves with every update the questionnaire cannot see. One configured hard-liner shifted a whole AI team's negotiation by tens of thousands of euros — in the one model family that transmits temperament; the other family absorbed the same member as rhetoric. From the field: the role an organisation assigns its advisors — human or artificial — follows its decision latency, not its national culture (Austria at power distance 11 and Romania at 90 cast the same servant), and predictability follows not how strong a situation is but whether its strength is written down.

For Monday morning

Characterise the situation before reading anyone's profile. Design the team's first round instead of predicting it. Contract the advisor's role rather than letting the clock assign it. And before an AI colleague joins a team, profile it like a hire — per role, per model version, with the behavioral battery and not just the questionnaire — then re-profile on every update.

The invitation

The framework's next tests need partners more than funding. An organisation willing to lend one profiled team for five weeks can run the composition experiment's human phase. A faculty co-author with access to expatriate managers can run the multi-country test of the advisor-role and codification findings. A practitioner with one client conversation to spare can pilot the clock-and-codification diagnostic. Write to codrut@lazaroiu.at.

Full paper: "The Clock, Not the Culture: Predicting Workplace Behavior from the Individual to the Multinational in the Age of AI Colleagues," working paper, 2026.